



Investigation report

Rejected take-off and runway overrun, Tarlton Springs - Executive brief

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INVESTIGATION WORKFLOW SUITE

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What happened

On 18 June 2026, Saltbush Air flight SB512, a 50-seat twin-turboprop aircraft registered VH-SBQ, was preparing to depart from runway 09 at Tarlton Springs Aerodrome. On board were 44 passengers, two flight crew and one cabin crew member. The departure took place in the hour after last light. The aerodrome's only runway inspection for the day had been carried out at 21:35 UTC on 17 June, before the first scheduled arrival, and had recorded the movement area as clear. At 07:29 UTC the tower cleared the aircraft for take-off, with the wind passed as 090 at 6 kt. The tower did not offer a runway inspection and the crew did not request one. No wildlife report had been made on the tower frequency in the preceding 90 minutes. The first officer was flying the aircraft. The take-off roll began at 07:30:02 with both engines producing matching power, and V1 was called at 112 kt. Two seconds later the first officer called "Roos - roos, roos, on the left", having seen two kangaroos crossing the runway from the northern side to the southern side, an estimated 200 m ahead. The take-off was rejected with the call "Stopping. I have control." The power levers reached flight idle within 0.6 seconds. At that point the aircraft was at 118 kt, 6 kt and 3 seconds past V1, with 695 m of sealed runway remaining.

About one second later the aircraft struck both animals. Three blades of the No. 2 propeller were damaged beyond limits, and reverse thrust on that engine was unavailable for the rest of the stop. Maximum braking was established two seconds after the decision to stop, compared with a fleet average of 3.2 seconds, and anti-skid was active on all four wheels. No. 1 reverse was selected at 07:30:36. The deceleration achieved was below the aircraft's scheduled stopping performance. The aircraft left the end of the sealed runway at approximately 21 kt at 07:30:51, and its deceleration fell from 2.6 m/s² on the seal to 1.9 m/s² in the graded gravel. It came to rest at 07:30:57, upright and on the extended centreline, 62 m into the 90 m runway end safety area (the cleared strip beyond the runway end). This was 28 m short of the end of the prepared area, beyond which the ground is ungraded. There was no fire. At the pilot in command's request, the tower activated the aerodrome emergency plan at 07:32:10. Passengers left by the forward airstair in a precautionary disembarkation between 07:34:40 and 07:38:48. No evacuation was commanded. There were no serious injuries, although one cabin crew member reported bruising during the disembarkation. The aircraft was substantially damaged. Both right main tyres deflated, the right main gear doors were distorted, the lower right fuselage was punctured, and a shock-load inspection of the engine was required. Both kangaroos were killed, and the aerodrome was closed for 4 hours 20 minutes.

Why it happened

The occurrence began with two kangaroos entering the runway strip and moving onto the sealed surface, and it was extremely likely that this contributed. The crew saw the animals after the aircraft had passed V1, and the take-off was rejected 6 kt above V1. It was extremely likely that this decision contributed. The investigation found it likely that the decision was influenced by the scope of rejected take-off training, which covered aircraft system failures below V1 only. This was a safety issue.

After the take-off was rejected, the No. 2 propeller and the right main gear struck both kangaroos. It was virtually certain that the strike contributed. Together with the rejection above V1, the strike led to a deceleration below the aircraft's scheduled stopping performance, and it was virtually certain that this shortfall contributed to the aircraft overrunning the runway into the runway end safety area. Maximum braking and No. 1 reverse were applied without delay. It was very likely that this prompt response influenced where the aircraft came to rest.

The kangaroos were on the runway for several connected reasons. The aircraft departed in the hour after last light, which is the peak period of kangaroo movement, and it was likely that this timing contributed. The repair of the aerodrome perimeter fence had been deferred for three budget cycles. It was very likely that this deferral contributed to the animals reaching the runway, and it was a safety issue. A documented wildlife plan was required only at aerodromes above a size threshold, and Tarlton Springs did not meet that threshold. It was likely that this requirement influenced both the fence deferral and the runway inspection arrangements described below. This was also a safety issue.

No runway inspection was requested before this first departure after last light, and it was likely that this contributed to the animals being on the runway undetected. A runway inspection was required only at listed aerodromes, and the criterion for listing an aerodrome was a strike. It was very likely that this arrangement influenced the absence of an inspection request, and it was a safety issue. The evening service had been approved as a schedule change, and the route risk assessment was not reopened. It was likely that this influenced the runway inspection arrangement that applied to the departure. This was a safety issue.

The investigation also examined whether the intensity of the runway edge lighting reduced the crew's ability to detect the animals. It could not resolve this question, and it was about as likely as not. The lighting intensity was measured, but the measurement was taken seven days after the occurrence. Nothing showed what the lights were doing on the night. The two accounts of the lighting disagreed. No study was found that links an edge light reading of 131% to the detection of an object on the sealed surface. The investigation therefore drew no conclusion about whether the lighting played any part in the detection of the animals. Resolving the question would require [NOT ESTABLISHED: what evidence or study would be needed to resolve the lighting question].

What we found

A finding stated without a likelihood term was established as fact.

Contributing safety factors

- With virtual certainty, a documented wildlife plan was required only above a size threshold the aerodrome did not meet, and it was likely that this requirement contributed to the occurrence. (Safety issue)
- The perimeter fence repair had been deferred for three budget cycles, which was virtually certain, and this deferral very likely contributed to the occurrence. (Safety issue)
- It was very likely that the departure took place in the hour after last light, the peak of kangaroo movement, and it was likely that this timing contributed to the occurrence.
- It was virtually certain that the evening service was approved as a schedule change and that the route risk assessment was not reopened, and this approval probably contributed to the occurrence. (Safety issue)
- That a runway inspection was required only at listed aerodromes, with a strike as the listing criterion, was virtually certain, and this arrangement very likely contributed to the occurrence. (Safety issue)
- It was virtually certain that no runway inspection was requested before the first departure after last light, and it was likely that this contributed to the occurrence.
- With virtual certainty, two kangaroos entered the runway strip and moved onto the sealed surface, and their presence very likely contributed to the occurrence.
- Rejected take-off training very likely covered aircraft system failures below V1 only, and this training scope probably contributed to the occurrence. (Safety issue)
- The recorded flight data established with virtual certainty that the take-off was rejected 6 kt above V1, and this decision very likely contributed to the occurrence.
- The No. 2 propeller and right main gear struck two kangaroos, and this strike contributed to the occurrence, both with virtual certainty.
- Deceleration achieved below the scheduled accelerate-stop performance was established with virtual certainty, and with virtual certainty this shortfall contributed to the occurrence.

Other factors that increased risk

- With virtual certainty, the cabin floor proximity emergency lighting (the lighting strip along the aisle floor that marks the escape path) was partially unserviceable, and it was very likely that this increased risk. (Safety issue)
- The crew were operating a fifth sector, 11 hours into duty, 40 minutes behind schedule, which was virtually certain, and it was likely that this increased risk.

Other findings

- The investigation examined whether the take-off commenced with a tailwind above limits, and ruled it out.
- A No. 2 engine power loss during the take-off roll was examined and ruled out.
- Maximum braking and No. 1 reverse applied without delay were examined and found to reduce risk.

What is being done

Documented wildlife plan required only above a size threshold. Aerodrome Standard AS-139 requires a documented wildlife hazard management plan only at aerodromes above a size threshold, and Tarlton Springs falls below it. No action has been recorded against this issue by the body responsible for the standard or by the aerodrome operator. [NOT ESTABLISHED: any action taken or proposed, and its status]

Perimeter fence repair deferred for three budget cycles. The northern fence remained unrepaired when the investigation inspected it on 23 June 2026. No action has been recorded against this issue. [NOT ESTABLISHED: any decision by the aerodrome operator to fund or carry out the repair, and its status]

Evening service approved as a schedule change, route risk assessment not reopened. On 19 June 2026 the Head of Flying Operations suspended the evening Tarlton Springs service. No reopening or reissue of the route risk assessment (RRA-041) has been recorded. [NOT ESTABLISHED: whether the operator has reviewed its change management process or RRA-041, and the status of the suspension]

Runway inspection required only at listed aerodromes, with a strike as the listing criterion. On 2 July 2026 the investigation raised the listing criterion with the operator's Safety Department. Under that criterion only a reported strike can place an aerodrome on the list, and no provision asks crews to report sightings. The investigation proposes that this issue be the subject of a recommendation in its own right. [NOT ESTABLISHED: the Safety Department's response, and its status]

Rejected take-off training covers aircraft system failures below V1 only. No action has been recorded against this issue. [NOT ESTABLISHED: any change proposed to TRG-SYL-07 module 4 or Operations Manual Part B 4.6, and its status]

Cabin floor proximity emergency lighting partially unserviceable. The operator's engineering area is examining whether the same failed ballast affects other aircraft of the type. That question remains open. [NOT ESTABLISHED: the engineering finding, any rectification on VH-SBQ, and any change to the 24-month functional check interval]



Figure 1: The northern perimeter fence at the 1,050 m mark, photographed on the site visit: the fallen section and the animal pad through it. Site inspection photograph SV-2026-0417-07, northern boundary at the 1,050 m runway marker, taken 23/06/2026

Distribution

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